

The Washington Post

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Morning flurries 43/26 • Tomorrow: Cold 40/32 C16

Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, FEBRUARY 23, 2026 • \$4

Golden ending



DAVID W. CERNY/REUTERS

The U.S. men's hockey team celebrates after beating Canada, 2-1 in overtime, on Sunday in Milan to capture its first Olympic gold medal since the "Miracle on Ice" squad's historic triumph in 1980. More coverage in Sports, C1.

DHS pulls reversal, won't suspend TSA PreCheck

BY MARIANNE LEVINE,
RILEY BEGGIN
AND THEODORIC MEYER

The Department of Homeland Security reversed course Sunday morning after saying that it would suspend TSA PreCheck because of the partial government shutdown. "TSA PreCheck remains operational with no change for the traveling public," the Transportation Security Administration said in a

Plan to halt popular travel program was met with swift criticism

statement. "As staffing constraints arise, TSA will evaluate on a case by case basis and adjust operations accordingly."

A DHS official, speaking on the

condition of anonymity to discuss internal processes, said the change was "based off of conversations the secretary had with the White House and TSA." The Global Entry program, however, will remain paused, according to the official. TSA PreCheck and Global Entry are two popular programs that allow some travelers to move more quickly through airport security. Homeland Security Secretary

Kristi L. Noem had said in a statement Saturday that the agency was "making tough but necessary workforce and resource decisions" and prioritizing the "general traveling population" at airports and other ports of entry. Saturday's announcement that TSA PreCheck would be suspended had drawn swift criticism. The ranking Democrat on the House Homeland Security Committee,

SEE DHS ON A7

European rule of law magnifies U.S. inaction on Epstein files

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA
AND ELLEN FRANCIS

As the U.S. Justice Department demurs from new inquiries linked to the Epstein files, the approach by European authorities stands in stark contrast. On the other side of the Atlantic, governments are promising to hold the wealthy, powerful and politically connected to account. Under public scrutiny, officials in Britain, France, Norway and beyond have opened a flurry of investigations and independent commissions to look into evidence of potential crimes in more than 3 million files related to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein that were released last month by congressional order. In three weeks, the revelations have prompted resignations, raids and other legal actions, none more notable than the detention Thursday of Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, the younger brother of King Charles III, on suspicion of misconduct in office. "Nobody is above the law," British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said on television shortly before the arrest. Starmer delivered that statement even as the tide of accountability knocked at the door of 10 Downing Street. Communications made public in the files

SEE EPSTEIN ON A9



ULISES RUIZ/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Mexican army kills cartel boss

A Mexican National Guardsman stands near a bus that was set on fire in retaliation for an army operation that killed "El Mencho," the leader of the Jalisco New Generation Cartel. **Story, A13**

A governor's bitter backyard border battle

BY MATT VISER
AND SARAH BLASKEY

In a leafy Philadelphia suburb, a petty neighborhood dispute over mundane issues of land surveys and town ordinances has escalated into a bizarre saga featuring political attacks and confrontations at property lines.

On one side sits Josh Shapiro, governor of the largest swing state, Pennsylvania, and a rising Democratic star who is running for reelection and has political aspirations that may reach the White House. On the other sit his neighbors, the Mocks. At issue is a narrow 10-foot-wide peninsula, a comically small

spit of land along the Shapiros' property line that broadens slightly into a small chunk of someone's backyard. Whose yard depends on whom you ask. On paper, the land belongs to the Mocks. But the Shapiros, seeking to build a security fence, have claimed in court to have squatters'

SEE SHAPIRO ON A7

Man shot, killed inside perimeter of Mar-a-Lago

POLICE SAY INDIVIDUAL HAD A SHOTGUN

Trump was not at his residence in South Florida

BY MARIANA ALFARO,
CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.
AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

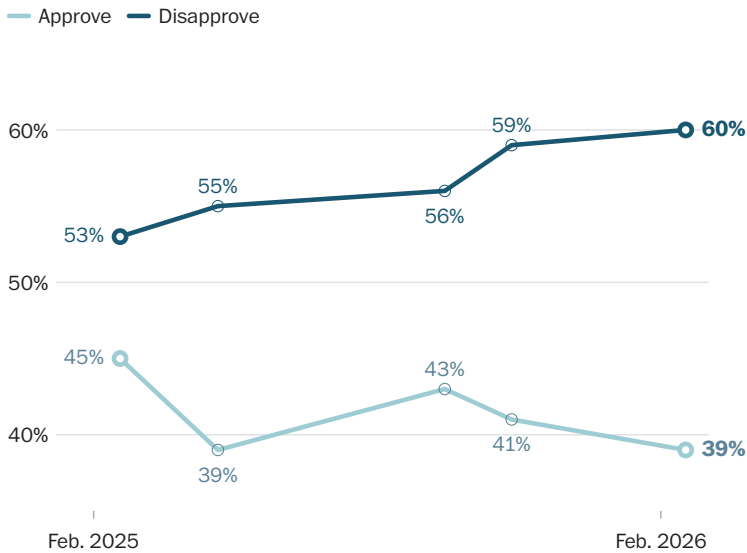
U.S. Secret Service agents and a Palm Beach County sheriff's deputy shot and killed a man who entered the secure perimeter of President Donald Trump's Mar-a-Lago estate early Sunday morning, the Secret Service said in a statement. Trump was not at Mar-a-Lago this weekend. Palm Beach County Sheriff Ric Bradshaw told reporters Sunday morning that the individual, identified as Austin Tucker Martin, a 21-year-old White man from Cameron, North Carolina, was carrying a gas canister and a shotgun. Bradshaw confirmed the identification of Martin after initially withholding it until officials could notify his family. According to Bradshaw, the officers confronted Martin around 1:30 a.m. and ordered

him to put down the gas canister and the gun. He put down the canister and "raised the shotgun to a shooting position," Bradshaw said. "At that point in time, the deputy and the two Secret Service agents fired their weapons" and killed the man, who died at the scene, Bradshaw said. Bradshaw said the incident happened "just inside the inner perimeter" of Mar-a-Lago, near the estate's north gate. No officers were injured during the incident at Mar-a-Lago, officials said. Martin's family had reported him missing Saturday. An art website and an Instagram account that appear connected to Martin heavily feature drawings and illustrations of golf courses. Mar-a-Lago is several miles away from one of Trump's signature golf courses, the Trump International Golf Club in West Palm Beach.

SEE MAR-A-LAGO ON A9

Approval of President Donald Trump's job performance

Q: Do you approve or disapprove of the way Trump is handling his job as president?



No opinion/Skipped not shown.

Source: Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos polls. Latest poll conducted Feb. 12-17, 2026, among 2,589 U.S. adults with a margin of error of +/- 2 percentage points.

Trump has wide disapproval entering State of the Union

Poll shows 60 percent do not approve of president's performance

BY DAN BALZ
AND SCOTT CLEMENT

As President Donald Trump prepares to address the nation Tuesday evening, Americans remain generally sour about his performance, with majorities disapproving of his handling of priority initiatives while saying he has overreached the authority of his office, according to a Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll. The president's approval rating stands at 39 percent positive and 60 percent negative, including 47 percent who say they strongly disapprove. The last time Trump's disapproval touched 60 percent was shortly after the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol. Among registered voters, Trump's approval is 41 percent and his disapproval is

58 percent. Dissatisfaction with Trump applies to specific issues, as well, with significant majorities saying they disapprove of how he is handling the economy, tariffs, inflation and relations with other countries. His worst rating is on inflation — 32 percent approve of how he has dealt with the issue. On the question of his handling of the economy overall, 41 percent approve, but while he still gets low ratings on this, the gap between negative and positive assessments has narrowed from 25 points negative in October to negative 16 this month. For Democrats, Trump's relatively low standing provides opportunities for the upcoming midterm elections, but the party out of power has made little headway in persuading Americans that it has better ideas or policies to offer and are seen as no more in touch with the concerns of the average person. Asked whether they trust Trump or Democrats in Congress to handle major issues, 33 percent

SEE POLL ON A8

IN THE NEWS

Cutting diversity efforts The Trump administration's objection to partnerships that help people of color pursue doctoral degrees has resulted in universities ending them. A5

Help not wanted President Donald Trump stirs confusion at home and abroad with talk of sending a 'hospital boat' to Greenland. A6

THE WORLD Israeli leader Benjamin Netanyahu is pressing to shut down a popular state-funded, military-run public broadcaster, saying its programming befits a dictatorship, not a democracy. A12

THE ECONOMY The U.S. economy cooled sharply at the end of 2025, with growth slowing to an annual rate of 1.4 percent as tariffs and a government shutdown cut earlier momentum. A16

STYLE Hollywood memorabilia auctions can extend the connection for nostalgic fans of bygone TV shows and enhance their wardrobes at bargain prices. That explains how Keri Russell's show-prop boots wound up inside a reporter's closet. B1

SPORTS The Milan Cortina Winter Olympics came to a fitting end Sunday night with a celebration inside a nearly 2,000-year-old outdoor arena located about 100 miles from where the main action has taken place over the past two weeks. C1

THE REGION A Potomac island was a haven for a small and dedicated group. Hundreds of millions of gallons of sewage spilling into the river made it unreachable. C7

The death of a man who wrote a murder mystery is one in Montgomery County. C7

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